“***The Interim***”

In death, our protagonist finds himself in an obscure kind of purgatory with an even stranger Guide. In order to pass on, the protagonist must sort through memories of its life and protect his candle - or be stuck in the Interim, forever changed.

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Are you hungry?

“No, thank you.”

Cold, then? Or, too hot?

“I don’t feel anything.”

Of course. You must be tired.

“Yes. Like my body is made of stone, and I’ve been cast into the river.”

Death is a heavy burden. I understand.

You can wake if you wish it.

“Please. I would like to wake up.”

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There is no color. The sights are foreign and gorgeous; a wreath of mountains, like shattered teeth, decorated with black pines. An array of vines and flowers I cannot name surrounding my bed - my small, comfortable bed with butterfly patterns.

Take it. Ten voices speak as one. All deep, all grating; like they’re all fighting to be heard from the depths of somewhere.

I turn in my head to the choir and see a horror: the skull of a bird the size of an elephants head. There is no neck and no visible body except for a curtain of rags and robes hovering half a foot above the floor. I see husked remains of arms, long and spindling twigs with bone showing through patches of papery skin. One of the arms droops low with an offering - a candle burning on an iron holder.

Take it, I said. The monster urges, pushing the candle closer to me.

“Why?” I manage.

Because it's yours, it says, *I can only hold it for so long*.

It thrusts the candle into my grasp. Then, it straightens itself; twice my height standing. My spine is rigid, and I have the strangest fear that if I look away it won't be there when I look back.

You have nice manners, the skull coos, *Most protest. "Do not go quietly into that good night" and all that*.

It takes a minute for my voice to dislodge from my throat, "I'd scream if not for…well, what good would it do?"

A satisfied hum reverberates out of the skull.

You want to do good then?

"Yes…if there is any good to be done in a place like this."

In the Interim there is always work *to be done.*

"You would have me work?"

You were a young man in your life. Too young to earn any callouses on your fingers. Your back is strong and you have a persistent energy about you. Your time here is limited. Why not be productive?

"Limited? How long do I have?"

The massive beak above me tilts down until the sharp point of it is aimed at the candle. In the time we have exchanged words, a fingernails length has melted away.

"And when it's gone? Where will I go?"

My mother would tell me stories of heaven. She was always devoted to scripture. Sometimes it felt as though she thought of me less as a son and more of a heathen in need of saving. Perhaps I could use some saving now.

That depends. If all the wax melts away, given time and protection, you will know where to go. In a breath, I'm inches away from the eye hole of the monster. *But, if the flame is snuffed, you will remain here as a Guide*.

"A guide?" A guide to where? A guide for who? And how will I know where to guide them in this place? Before my questions can flood out, a withered hand cricks in front of my face, to silence me.

You can ask all the questions on your mind and all the ones to come, but by the time you're satisfied with my answers your candle will have long gone out. The decrepit hand recedes away, *I suggest you spend your time more fruitfully.*

"Fruitfully how?"

Another question. Let's begin by standing - carefully now, watch the flame.

For a moment, it feels as though my legs don't exist, until I use them to kick off the covers, and rise - carefully, per the monster's instruction. The heaviness I felt in the darkness has entirely inverted. I'm nearly weightless, like all of the organs and bones within me have vanished and left me with nothing but skin and soul. Left bare of clothing and strangely enough, bare of embarrassment. Here, naked as the day I was born, I feel no judgemental eyes watching or self-conscious thoughts urging me to cover myself - even in the presence of this cloaked thing.

Next, we will walk to your Branch. The beak swings west, and at the far side of the cobblestone bridge, there is a large domed building that reminds me of an observatory. I take a few steps before I'm halted in my tracks by a hand.

I must go first. As your Guide.

Swiftly, and with little empathy, a silent question is answered. A little bit of weight finds its way into my chest as the Guide passes in front of me towards the Branch, and I follow.

As we walk, I take in more of the monochrome landscape. On either side of the cobble bridge there are acres of mist hiding whatever lies below. Cutting through the white fog like lines of graphite on paper are…more bridges. No support beams, no beginning or end that I can see. No people, or Guides, walking along their pathways.

I refocus, and realize my walk is complete. Before me is the Branch, and a doorway reaching up to the arcing dome of the roof being held open by the Guide.

Don't get distracted. There are many treasures I'm sure you'll find dear. Try to remember you are here to work, and your time…

"...is limited." I finish. The beak bobs in a pleasant nod. "You still haven't told me what work it is I'll be doing. Gravedigging?"

A gruesome cackle gargles out of the beak, *No. Nothing so macabre. Cleaning.* The skull passively nods indoors, and I enter the round room. Surrounding me are thousands of tomes scattered about the mosaic floor; a design that looks like a soaring white crane. I turn to face the Guide.

"Will you join me?"

I have already done my work. It's an intimate process best handled in private. I will remain on the bridge, waiting.

The Guide says concretely. I end our idle talk with a simple, "Thank you.", and let the Guide shut the door. I realize there are no windows and no lanterns - only shelves, and the odd ladder among the hurricane remains of literature. All that illuminates the room is my small candle, now three fingernails shorter.

I decide it's best to begin left to right. I kneel and set the candle gently to my side to illuminate the stack as best as possible while I observe the books and scoop them into my arms.

Some of the titles are familiar: "*Tom Sawyer*", "*Treasure Island*", others are thinner, and completely unknown: "*First Beach*", "*Flowers at Bowling Green*". Stories I'm certain I've never read, but the titles tug on my heart and whisper faint inklings of knowing. I look around and survey the clutter once more. There must be tens of thousands of books. My eyes fall again to the candle. It won't be enough time to sort this all, I'm sure. But that's not what the Guide said - only that by the time the candle is melted, I will know where to go. The candle is all that matters, all the rest is just busy work.

By the time the candle is halfway melted, I've finished one and a half full shelves. Hours have passed, hours that aren't worth keeping track of. I thought the candle would have gone out long ago, but it remains burning bright. Sorting through the mess, I realize there are far more than just books in the room; there are trinkets, and other lost loved things. I've sorted through the lettered blocks that helped me learn the alphabet as a child, puzzles I've solved with my father, and playing cards I would use with my friends.

The monotony and repetition is draining, yet, I remain awake, the candle remains burning, and the Guide remains on the bridge. As I bring order to the room, slowly but surely, order forms within me. Like remembering a dream, I imagine what will come after the Branch is cleaned. My mother spoke of green fields and white clouds, warm weather and people interloping without malice. Perfection. I always thought I could find her idea of perfection in the parks like Bowling Green. The idea in my mind is not much different from where I am now, "the Interim", as the Guide called it. Impossibilities: mist that hides beauties, flora and fauna the likes of which could never be seen.

“The stones say that there are dragons beyond the mountains.” A mans voice sounds out from under the mass. Slowly, I whisk the candle toward the voice. No Guide, no man, only small rises of miscellanea, and a small black stallion made of wool.

“Dragons aren’t real.” I utter to no one in particular, eyeing each book.

“Neither are bird skulled monsters that float.” The horse says.

“I know you,” I say to it, “you and I played when I was a boy. You were my favorite toy.”

“I was your best friend. Sending me into every make-believe conquest you could conjure. Do you remember the Battle of Moonbay?” The voice husks.

“I’m afraid not.” I loose a small laugh.

“I do. I remember them all.” The horse says with fondness. “This place has a way of making memories come to life. It’s fascinating, don’t you agree?”

“Fascinating is a good word for it.”

“I think so too. Do you remember when you had me play a Conquistador?”

I dig for the memory, but find only dirt, “Not quite.”

“You would say: ‘*To explore is to live*’, and send me into the wild - to live.” The horse hisses in eagerness. “I’m living now, my friend.”

My smile loses its authenticity as I continue to arrange a shelf, “So you are.”

“I like it.”

Discomfort takes over and my smile subsides. There is no response I can think of to this strange interaction with this strange animation.

“You know,” the horse continues, “that when you go, we go as well. There’s no need for us where you’ll be going.”

Don’t get distracted. I try my best to ignore the horse, to pretend I don’t hear its words.

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“We have only just arrived. We have only just begun to *live*.” the horse grumbles impatiently, “You would turn on your own words? You would leave such a world unexplored?”

“I was a simple minded child.” I snap, turning away from the shelf, holding the candle between myself and the horse.

“You still are a child.” the horse whispers, “And, you are still simple.”

The horse inches itself forward and places its head over the candle - extinguishing it, leaving us both in darkness. Then, a light blooms under the horses chin, that sparks into flame, engulfing its head, and then its body.

“For you, my friend,” the horse croaks, “to truly…live.”

As the horse turns into a torch, my feet leave the floor. From the skin about my neck blooms gray cloth, unfurling down to my feet that I can no longer feel. I feel my head split from my neck, like tearing an end of bread. I feel my eyes stretch back and my lips push forward into a sharp and unnatural shape. My eyes melt away, yet I still see, and as I look down at my hands through the gray cloak, I see no decay; they are still my hands. The horse is a pile of ash.

A gentle knock raps at the door and I turn. The Guide stands in the doorway - a mirror.

Ah, the Guide utters solemnly, *I see…You will have more time to sort through your things then. My condolences.*

The door shuts once more, and I am alone, disfigured. My only companions within the Branch: ash, and a snuffed candle.

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